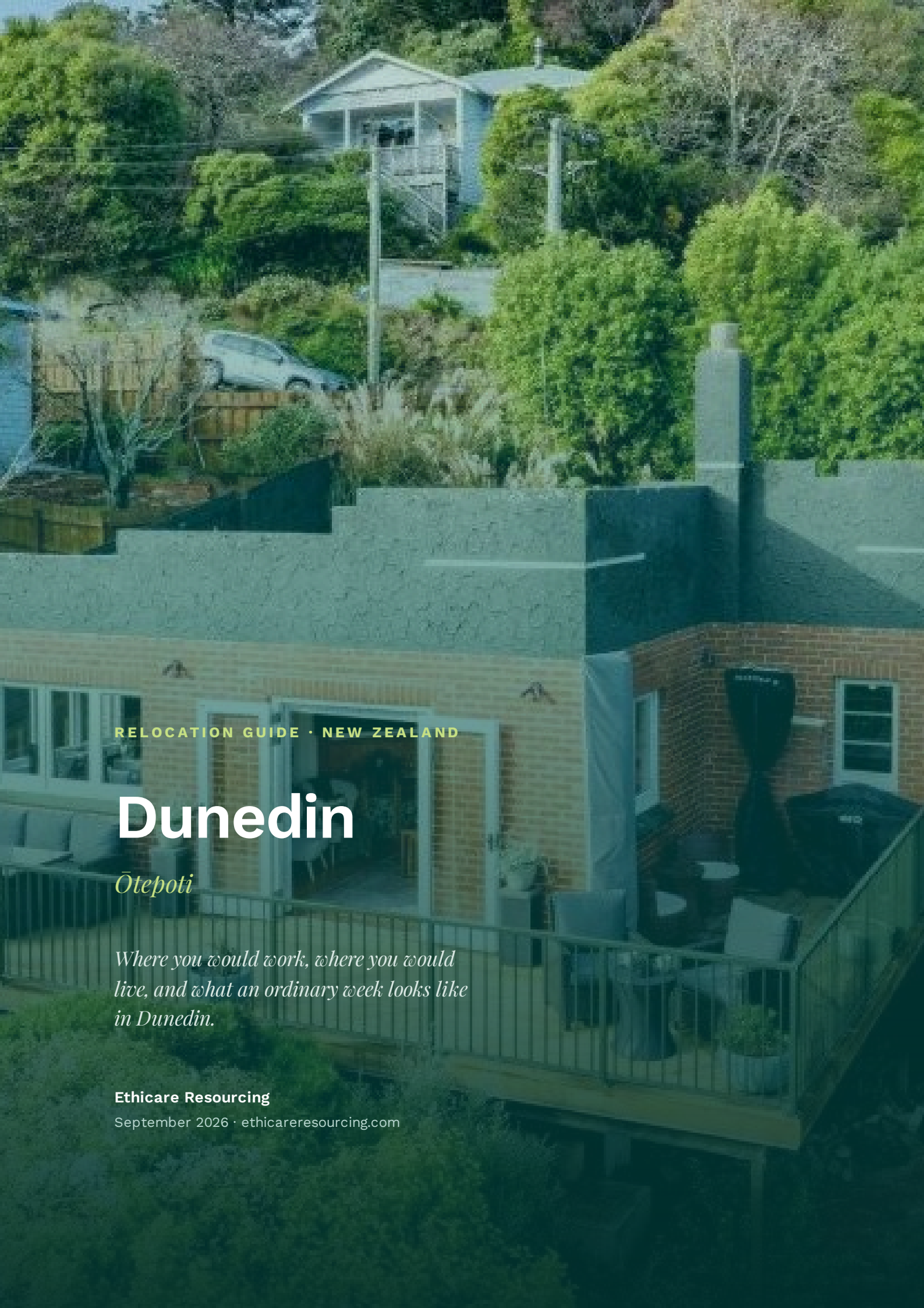




RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Dunedin

Ōtepoti

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Dunedin.

Ethicare Resourcing

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Nau mai ki Ōtepoti

Welcome to Dunedin

Moving country is a bold thing to do, and it is rarely only about the job. This guide is here to make the practical parts easier: where people live, what the work is like, how you would get around, and what an ordinary week might actually feel like.

It is written by people who arrange these moves for a living, which means two things. We know the questions that arrive at two in the morning. And we would rather tell you the awkward parts now than have you find them in month three.

Nothing in here is a pitch. If Dunedin turns out to be the wrong answer for you, this guide should help you work that out just as quickly – and that is a good outcome, not a failed one.

Whatever you decide, you are welcome to ask us anything at all.

Sophie

FOUNDER, ETHICARE RESOURCING

What's inside

01 **Welcome to Dunedin**

02 **Why Dunedin**

03 **Dunedin at a glance**

04 **Healthcare in Dunedin**

05 **Where clinicians live**

06 **Cost of living**

07 **Getting around**

08 **Food, shopping & the everyday**

09 **Wildlife & the coast**

This is the short version. Every section here has a fuller chapter on our website, kept up to date — so if something looks time-sensitive, check there. We have left rents, salaries and other figures out on purpose: a number that was right when this was written would be quietly wrong by the time you read it, and a PDF cannot be corrected once it is sent. Those live on the site instead.



01

NAU MAI, HAERE MAI

Welcome to Dunedin

Dunedin is the city people underestimate until they visit. It is small, it is a long way south, and it has a reputation for cold that is only half deserved. What it actually has is grand Victorian stone, New Zealand's oldest university, wildlife you would normally have to book a boat to see, and housing costs that make the rest of the country look unserious.

~130,000

People in the city. Small enough that you will start recognising faces within a month.

~20,000

University students. The single biggest thing shaping the city's rhythm, rents and nightlife.

1869

The University of Otago founded — New Zealand's oldest, and home to its first medical school.

Seven things you only learn once you are here

A tertiary teaching hospital and the country's oldest medical school, in a small Victorian city where your money goes further than anywhere else in New Zealand — and where the compromise is distance, not quality of life.

What follows is Dunedin-specific. Anything national — visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools — is explained once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than repeated here.

Why Dunedin

The case for Dunedin is easy to make badly. Said one way it sounds like a compromise: cheaper, smaller, further away. Said honestly, it is a genuinely different proposition — the same national pay and a tertiary case mix, in a city where you can own a character home ten minutes from work.

YOUR SALARY GOES FURTHEST HERE

Health New Zealand pays national agreement rates, so the number on your contract is the same as it would be in Auckland. Housing is not. That gap is the single strongest argument for Dunedin, and it compounds every year you stay.

A TEACHING HOSPITAL, AND A MEDICAL SCHOOL ATTACHED TO IT

Dunedin is a tertiary centre serving a large southern catchment, tightly bound to the University of Otago. If teaching, research or supervision is part of how you want to work, the infrastructure is already here and the door is not hard to find.

THE COMMUTE GIVES YOU YOUR EVENING BACK

Fifteen minutes is normal. For a lot of people this is the change they notice most — not the salary, not the scenery, but arriving home before six with the day still in it.

The six things people ask us

The city's tertiary hospital is also the base of New Zealand's oldest medical school, which shapes everything — teaching is woven into the work, research is accessible, and the academic culture is genuinely unusual for a city this size. If you want to teach, publish or subspecialise in an academic setting, this is the best-value place in the country to do it.

Colder than most of New Zealand, and the honest answer is that the cold is not the problem — the wind and the old housing are. Dunedin has a large stock of Victorian and Edwardian villas, beautiful and often poorly insulated. A well-insulated modern house here is perfectly comfortable; a cold flat is genuinely miserable. Chapter five is blunt about how to tell the difference.

When we'd point you north

We would rather you read this now than discover it in year two.

People who want a serious clinical job without a serious mortgage, who like the outdoors close rather than far, and who are genuinely at peace with being a long way from everywhere else.



03

THE SHAPE OF THE PLACE

Dunedin at a glance

Dunedin sits at the head of a long, narrow harbour on the south-east coast of the South Island, with hills on three sides and the open Pacific on the fourth.

Understanding that shape explains almost everything about how the city works.

THE FLAT AND THE CENTRE

The Octagon, the university, the hospital and the warehouse precinct all sit on reclaimed flat land at the harbour head. Walkable, and where most of the working day happens.

THE HILL SUBURBS

Roslyn, Māori Hill, Mornington and their neighbours climb the western slope. Views, villas, good schools, steep streets, and a few degrees cooler than the flat.

THE COAST

St Clair and St Kilda face the open sea to the south, with a surf beach and an esplanade. Andersons Bay and Musselburgh sit behind them, sheltered and family-heavy.

The climate, honestly

Dunedin has a cool temperate maritime climate. The sea moderates it in both directions: summers are mild rather than hot, and winters are cool rather than freezing. The mean annual temperature is around 11°C, and hard frosts are less common than people expect from the latitude.

What defines the year is not cold, it is variability and cloud. A February day can be 25°C and still. A February week can be 15°C and grey. Locals dress in layers and stop discussing it.

The shape of the place

Dunedin sits at the head of a long harbour, with the city built up the slopes of an ancient volcanic basin. The flat central grid – the Octagon, the university, the hospital, the warehouse district – occupies the harbour floor, and everything else climbs.

Out along the harbour's northern shore the road runs to Port Chalmers, the working port. On the southern side, the Otago Peninsula stretches twenty kilometres to Taiaroa Head, with albatross, penguins and sea lions at the end of it. Behind the city to the west, the hill suburbs give way quickly to farmland and then to Central Otago.

Healthcare in Dunedin

A LARGE CATCHMENT, A SMALL CITY

Tertiary referrals arrive from across Otago and Southland. You see complexity that a city of 130,000 would not otherwise generate.

TEACHING IS BUILT IN

Medical, nursing, dentistry, physiotherapy and pharmacy students are all trained here. If supervision and teaching interest you, the opportunity is immediate.

A NEW HOSPITAL IS BEING BUILT

A major rebuild of the Dunedin campus is underway — a long, publicly debated project that will run for years yet. Ask about timelines and interim arrangements for your service at interview; the picture differs considerably by department.

A tertiary hospital, and the medical school next to it

The city's tertiary hospital serves the lower South Island, run by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. It provides the full range of secondary services for the city and the wider Otago region, and tertiary services — the complex work that smaller hospitals refer on — for a catchment reaching south to Southland and inland across Central Otago.

What makes it distinctive is the university. The Otago Medical School, New Zealand's first, sits immediately alongside, and the two are structurally intertwined: joint appointments are common, students and registrars are everywhere, and research is a normal part of the working environment rather than something you do in your own time.

A second system, close at hand

Dunedin's private sector is small but real — planned surgery, endoscopy, diagnostics and day procedures, funded by insurance, by ACC, by patients directly, and increasingly by Health New Zealand outsourcing elective lists.

Because the city is compact, working across both sectors is straightforward: a public list in the morning and a private list in the afternoon is a ten-minute drive, not a lost day. Many senior clinicians hold appointments in both.



05

FOURTEEN SUBURBS

Where clinicians live

Fourteen suburbs, sorted by commute to wherever you will actually work. Dunedin is small enough that nothing is far, so the choice here is not about distance — it is about height, sun and how old you want your house to be.

ONE · FLAT, HILL OR COAST?

The three versions of living here. The flat is walkable and close to work. The hill gives you views, character housing and a few degrees less warmth. The coast gives you a beach at the end of the street and salt air on everything you own. Drive all three before you decide.

TWO · HOW WARM IS THE HOUSE?

The single most important question in Dunedin, and the one newcomers ask last. Much of the housing stock is a century old and was built without insulation. A well-retrofitted villa is lovely; an untouched one is genuinely hard work in July. Ask about insulation, heating and sun before you ask about the kitchen.

THREE · WHICH WAY DOES IT FACE?

On a hill this far south, aspect decides everything. A north-facing section gets sun all winter; a south-facing one in a valley may get almost none between May and August. Visit in the morning and again at four o'clock.



Space, greenery and a view — the classic Dunedin hill house

Pick your site, then read down

Suburbs reorder by commute to whichever site you select. Rents are indicative weekly figures for a three-bedroom house as at July 2026 — treat them as a shape, not a quote.

Commutes are typical door-to-door driving times outside peak. Dunedin's peak adds perhaps five minutes. Rents move — check current listings before budgeting.

What your money buys here

This is the part that surprises people arriving from Auckland, London or Sydney.

How renting works nationally – applications, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is the same everywhere, and set out in [Renting in New Zealand](#).



06

THE NUMBERS

Cost of living

Because Health New Zealand pays national agreement rates, the salary on your contract is the same one you would earn in Auckland — it simply buys considerably more here.

HOUSING

The headline. Rents and house prices are well below Auckland, Wellington and Christchurch. A family home in a good suburb costs what a small flat costs further north.

TRANSPORT

Short commutes, cheap parking outside the hospital campus, and many households running one car instead of two.

POWER

The one that goes the other way. Winter heating in an older house is a real line in the budget, and the item newcomers most consistently underestimate.

Why there are no prices on this page

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you – which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Dunedin against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

What things cost

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is just over half of it – against the smallest main-centre rent line in the country.

Indicative figures that change over time. Use them as a shape, not a quote.

The winter power bill

This deserves its own heading because it catches almost everybody. A poorly insulated older house in Dunedin can cost two or three times as much to heat in July as it does to run in February. The same house, properly insulated with an efficient heat pump, costs a fraction of that.

The Healthy Homes standards have raised the floor for rentals considerably, which helps. But if you are buying, treat insulation, double glazing and heating as part of the purchase price rather than a later project. It is the best money you will spend here.

The student effect

Twenty thousand students distort the rental market in a way worth understanding. Demand peaks sharply in late January and February as the academic year begins, and slumps from November. Family homes in the hill and coastal suburbs are less affected than flats near the university – but if you can time your search for December, you will have more choice and less competition.

Tax, KiwiSaver, banking and sending money home are national topics, covered in [Money, tax & banking](#).

The bill that catches people out

Heating is the Dunedin budget line that surprises people, and it has almost nothing to do with how cold the city is. Dunedin winters are cooler than the North Island but not extreme; the issue is the housing stock.

The city has a large inventory of Victorian and Edwardian villas – beautiful, generously proportioned, and frequently built with single glazing, no wall insulation and high ceilings. A house like that costs several times more to keep warm than a modern equivalent, and the difference shows up on every winter bill for as long as you live there.

Three costs people forget

The same national salary against the lowest housing costs in the country – provided you spend some of the difference on keeping the house warm.

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

Getting around

Dunedin is the easiest city in New Zealand to get around, for one simple reason: there is not very much of it. The trade-off is gradient. This is a city where the question is rarely how far, and often how steep.

DRIVING

The default, and genuinely quick. Most people can be at the hospital from anywhere in the city inside twenty minutes. Hospital parking, as everywhere, is the actual constraint.

WALKING

The flat is entirely walkable — the Octagon, the university, the hospital and the warehouse precinct are within fifteen minutes of each other. Living on the flat means you may barely use a car midweek.

BUSES

The Orbus network covers the city and suburbs, with the main routes running frequently enough to rely on. Fares are low and a regional card makes them lower.

What the commute actually looks like

Fifteen minutes door to door is normal from most suburbs. Twenty-five from Mosgiel over the hill. The rush hour exists but it is a courtesy title — it means the lights take two cycles instead of one.

Do you need a car?

Realistically, yes — unless you live on the flat and rarely leave the city. Not for the commute, but for everything at the weekend: the peninsula, the beaches, Central Otago, the Catlins. Public transport does not reach the places that make living here worthwhile.

One car per household is usually enough, which is a meaningful saving over cities where two is assumed. Converting your licence, buying a car, a warrant of fitness and registration are national topics, covered in [Driving & licences](#).

The hills change everything

Dunedin is built into an amphitheatre around the harbour, and the contour line you live on shapes your daily life more than the distance does. A suburb that is two kilometres from the hospital can be a twenty-minute walk uphill, and the same walk in reverse takes ten.

This is the practical difference from Christchurch, which people often assume is comparable. Cycling here is genuinely hard work outside the flat central grid, and winter ice on steep streets is a real hazard that catches newcomers out. Some of the steepest residential streets in the world are here, and that is not a tourist statistic when your car is on one of them in July.

Food, shopping & the everyday

A city of 130,000 should not have this many good places to eat. It does, for two reasons: 20,000 students who need feeding cheaply, and a century of Scottish, Chinese and more recent Asian and Middle Eastern settlement that left its mark on the kitchens.

THE OCTAGON

The literal and social centre. Bars and restaurants ring the plaza, and on a warm evening the tables spill onto the grass in front of the town hall.

THE WAREHOUSE PRECINCT

Vogel and Bond Streets, where the Victorian warehouses have been restored into restaurants, breweries and design studios. The best-looking few blocks in Dunedin.

GEORGE STREET

The main shopping street, running north from the Octagon towards the university. Recently rebuilt as a slower, more pedestrian-friendly stretch.

Saturday at the station

The Otago Farmers Market runs every Saturday morning in the car park beside the railway station, and it is the closest thing the city has to a weekly civic ritual. Producers come in from the Taieri, Central Otago and the Catlins; you go for the vegetables and stay for the coffee and the whitebait fritter.

It is not a tourist market. Most of the city shops there, and after a couple of months you will recognise half the queue.

Beer, and the Scottish inheritance

Dunedin takes brewing seriously. The city has a long-established brewing tradition and a strong craft scene that grew out of it, with several breweries running taprooms you can walk between. If beer is your thing, this is one of the better small cities in the country for it.

The Scottish founding still shows in the street names, the architecture, the pipe bands and a certain civic seriousness — less in the food, though you will find haggis on a menu in January if you look.

Culture, for a small city

The public art gallery is free and good. There are three museums worth your time — the settlers' museum, the Otago Museum and the university's own collections. The Regent Theatre and a scattering of smaller venues cover touring theatre and music, and the student population keeps live music alive in a way that cities twice the size struggle to manage.

More good food, beer and culture than a city this size has any right to — because 20,000 students and 150 years of civic ambition both insist on it.

Wildlife & the coast

This is the chapter that persuades people. Dunedin's weekends are not a compromise for living somewhere small — they are the reason to do it. The wildlife is close and constant, the coast is wild, and Central Otago and the Catlins are close enough for a Saturday.

TAIAROA HEAD

Royal albatross, with a two-metre wingspan, nesting on a headland you can drive to. Also fur seals, shags and little blue penguins coming ashore at dusk.

SANDFLY BAY

A steep dune descent to a wild beach where sea lions haul out and yellow-eyed penguins come in at evening. Keep your distance — the sea lions are large and faster than they look.

LARNACH CASTLE

New Zealand's only castle, with gardens and views down both sides of the peninsula.

The peninsula

The Otago Peninsula runs twenty kilometres out from the city, and it is the single best thing about living here. At the far end, Taiaroa Head holds the only mainland breeding colony of royal albatross in the Southern Hemisphere. Along the way there are yellow-eyed penguins, little blue penguins, New Zealand sea lions, fur seals and a road that hugs the harbour the whole way.

You can do all of this on an ordinary Saturday afternoon, twenty minutes from your front door. People who move here from cities where nature is a holiday activity take about a year to stop being astonished by it.

The coast, and the water

St Clair and St Kilda give the city two surf beaches within ten minutes of the centre. St Clair has the hot saltwater pool at one end and a serious surf break at the other; there is a year-round swimming community that treats the cold water as a feature rather than an obstacle.

Further out, Tunnel Beach has a hand-carved tunnel down to a sea arch, and the coastline south towards the Catlins is emptier and wilder with every kilometre.

Winter, and the mountains

Dunedin is not a ski town, but it is closer to the snow than most cities. The Central Otago fields are within a comfortable drive for a long weekend, and Queenstown's are three and a half hours away. Plenty of people here ski a handful of times a season without it being the organising principle of their life.

Closer to home, winter means clear cold days on the peninsula, empty beaches, and a city that turns inward towards its pubs and galleries in a way that is pleasant.

What you give up

Honesty matters here. You give up warm ocean swimming, reliable summer heat, and the casual ability to be anywhere else in the country quickly. You give up a certain amount of choice — in restaurants, in shops, in the sheer number of things happening on a given evening.

What you get instead is space, quiet, and a landscape most people only see on holiday. For the clinicians who settle here, that trade stops feeling like a trade after about a year.

Where to go next

You do not need a moving date, a decision or a CV to talk to us. If Dunedin is on your list, tell us what you do and what you are weighing up, and we will be straight with you about whether we can help.

Everything on our website is free to read whether or not you ever work with us.

The full Dunedin guide – ethicareresourcing.com/destinations/dunedin-new-zealand

Registration pathway checker – ethicareresourcing.com/pathway-checker

What reaches your bank account – ethicareresourcing.com/take-home-pay

What the move itself costs – ethicareresourcing.com/cost-calculator

Talk to us – hello@ethicareresourcing.com
